HBA PROGRAM: Business Communication

BUSINESS 3302

Professor: Michele Martin	Assistant: Olga Aguilar
E-mail: mmartin@ivey.ca	Email: oaguilar@ivey.ca

LAND ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

Western University is situated on the traditional lands of the Anishinaabek, Haudenosaunee, Lunaapewak, and Chonnonton Nations, who have long-standing relationships to the land and region of southwestern Ontario and the city of London. The local First Nations communities are the Chippewas of the Thames First Nation, the Oneida Nation of the Thames, and the Munsee Delaware Nation.

INTRODUCTION

The objectives of this course include the following:

1. Developing your skill and confidence as a communicator.
2. Building your understanding of strategic communications (for use individually and in organizational settings).
3. Creating real-world opportunities for you to practice and test your new skills and competencies.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

The course focuses on four key areas which are interconnected.

1. Critical Thinking, Problem-Solving, and Interpersonal Skills
2. Business Writing
3. Presentation Skills (in person, standing, seated and in virtual settings)
4. Have Impact with Your Own Insights

Critical Thinking, Problem-Solving, and Interpersonal Skills

- Better understand yourself as a communicator.
- Develop skills to adapt to your audience.
- Understand and use a strategic approach in all your communication efforts.
- Learn to choose the most effective structure, style, and vehicle for delivering strategically sound written and spoken messages.

Business Writing

- Enhance your business writing. Have resources to support strong business writing.
- Organize a document, implement the principles of clear and concise business writing,

  and decide on the best written medium of communication.

- Analyze communication situations, explore alternatives, and recommend a course of action.

Presentation Skills

- Assess the audience. Prepare a presentation that informs, persuades, or fulfills the needs of a given occasion and employs visual aids/technology to enhance the message.
- Deliver presentations using appropriate and effective vocal and physical behaviors to enhance messages – presenting materials in a clear, logical structure with a well-organized introduction, body, and conclusion.

Have Impact with Your Own Insights

- Learn best practices to differentiate yourself through communication, ability to adapt and offer insights
- Practice building and developing communication that surpasses content generated through generative AI.

Throughout the course, students will have the opportunity to reflect on and discuss how the communication challenges organizations face have significant brand, reputation, and bottom-line impact. Students will also explore how those challenges can best be solved.

MATERIALS

You will have access to publicly available/accessible electronic resources. You will also draw on an electronic, Ivey Publishing case book.

Details are available on the LEARN/Canvas Page. Every effort has been made to use accessible, valuable, and vetted online materials to reduce costs. Each professor will also make materials available (as appropriate) in the Session/Class pages on LEARN or in class. The class schedule and assignments by session appear on LEARN. That is the most up-to-date version of the course and the classes. Please check the course site regularly for this information and other course news. *Students are responsible for staying on-top of any changes posted regarding readings, expectations, or assignments for example*.

GRADING COMPONENT SCHEME

We strive to evaluate all available information in order to calculate a final grade that fairly reflects the student's demonstrated capability in understanding and applying the course content. Evidence of this capability comes through classroom contribution, examinations, reports, and other evaluation tools that may be used throughout the course.

The grade in this course is a composite of the elements identified below. I will assign your grades for written and non-written work based on the following:

Class Contribution (individual) includes online and in class along with quizzes	30%
Executive Memo (individual)	15%
Seated Presentation (group)	5%
Presentation (20% individual/15% group)	35%
Communications Day Capstone (group)	15%
Total	100%

EXAMS AND MAKEUP EXAM POLICY – HBA

Fairness, Preparedness, and Academic Continuity

At Ivey, exams are more than assessments—they are reflections of professional readiness and academic growth. This policy upholds our values of Integrity, Courage, Inclusivity, and Community, and outlines a fair, transparent process for accessing makeup exams when unexpected challenges arise.

Policy Statement

Examinations are a core component of academic evaluation and professional development. Students are expected to treat exam schedules with the same seriousness as professional obligations.

In exceptional circumstances, students may request academic consideration in accordance with the **Academic Consideration Policy**.

Academic Consideration for Missed Exams

- Students must **formally request academic consideration** as soon as possible, before the scheduled exam.
- Requests must be **supported by appropriate documentation** and submitted within **48 hours** of the missed exam.
- Students should communicate **proactively** with their Academic Advisor to clarify requirements and access support.

Makeup Exam Policy

- Students **granted academic consideration** will be offered **one official makeup exam opportunity**.
- The makeup exam will be scheduled within the **same academic term**, where possible.
- Students must prepare fully and approach the makeup with professional responsibility.
- **Missing the makeup exam** will result in **unsatisfactory academic standing**.

- A **second makeup exam** will be authorized **only at the Dean's discretion** after a formal review.
- Unsatisfactory standing will **remain in effect** until the review is complete and lifted only if the second makeup is granted and passed.

CLASS CONTRIBUTION & ATTENDANCE

Attendance Policy

Fostering Personal Responsibility and Engagement Through Community Learning

This policy reflects Ivey's shared values of Integrity, Courage, Inclusivity, and Community. Attendance is more than a rule – it is a commitment to collaborative learning, shared accountability, and personal growth. In a case-based environment, presence and engagement are essential to both individual success and community learning.

Students are expected to attend all scheduled classes and participate meaningfully, demonstrated through respect for classmates and instructors. Consistent, respectful engagement is a critical part of professional conduct and directly supports learning and progression.

Attendance Expectations:

- Attendance is mandatory in most courses and detailed on the syllabus
- Students who miss more than five (5) 80-minute sessions may:
  - be placed in unsatisfactory standing
  - be ineligible to write final exams or assessments, regardless of academic consideration
- All absences – including those granted academic consideration – count toward the total, **except for absences due to religious observance**.
- Students nearing the 5-class absence threshold will receive email notification from their faculty, with their Academic Advisor copied. Students are encouraged to seek support.
- Students who reach 50% of the threshold before or by reading break will be enrolled in a learning strategies course at the discretion of the Faculty Director and Director of Culture, Inclusion, Student Support and Engagement.

Incomplete Attendance (e.g. lates)

- '**Late is Late'** – students arriving after discussion has begun, or who depart class before discussion has finished will be counted 'late'. Students will receive a contribution deduction (-1 point or 0 for the day)
- At the discretion of the instructor, students who leave and return to class may not be invited into later discussion. These students have missed important sections of discussion, and their comments may replay points made while they were out of class. To the extent possible, please use time between classes for breaks, calls, and other activities.

- Departing class and returning with food or beverages may be counted as disruptive/disrespectful behaviours.
- Students who miss more than 20 minutes of any class period should be counted as being absent.

ACADEMIC CONSIDERATION POLICY

Supporting Academic Success Through Personal Accountability and Collaborative Care

At Ivey, we recognize that personal and academic challenges may arise unexpectedly. This policy provides a fair, timely, and compassionate process for academic consideration—rooted in our values of Integrity, Courage, Inclusivity, and Community. It supports student well-being while maintaining academic standards.

Scope

This policy applies when a student:

- Misses a **non-contribution-based graded component** (e.g., exam, assignment, in-class test, group work) due to unforeseen illness or life events.
- Misses a component due to **Varsity or Case competition participation**, or **religious observance**.
- Experiences an **extended absence** impacting academic engagement.

Valid Grounds for Consideration

- **Catastrophic Events** – Bereavement, major accidents, etc.
- **Illness (Physical or Mental Health)** – Including chronic, acute, or temporary conditions.
- **Religious Observance** – Conflicting with academic obligations.
- **Varsity Commitments or Ivey Case Competitions** that conflict with assessments.

Important Notes

- All absences—including those with academic consideration—count toward total missed classes, **except religious observance**.
- Students nearing the 5-class threshold will be notified by faculty and copied to their Academic Advisor.
- Students who reach 50% of the threshold by reading break will be added to a learning strategies course at the discretion of the Faculty Director and Director of Culture, Inclusion, Student Support and Engagement.
- **Excessive absences may lead to unsatisfactory academic standing**, even with academic consideration.

Submission Process

Step	Action	Who	Deadline
1	Report absence (Varsity/Religious) via	Student	≥10 days before event

	LEARN & submit form/documentation		Students must submit supporting documentation with this request 10 days prior to the planned varsity event or Religious Observance.
2	Report absence (Illness/Catastrophe) via LEARN + Western Medical Documentation Form	Student	Within 48* hours of absence *A Western Medical Certificate needs to be obtained as soon as the student becomes ill, substantiating why the student was medically unfit to attend class on the assessment date.
3	Review & Verification	Academic Advisor	Within 3 business days
4	Receive Decision	Student	Upon completion of review

Community and Growth

Academic challenges are part of learning. This policy supports fairness while encouraging resilience, self-advocacy, and collaboration between students, faculty, and advisors.

Student Policy Responsibility Table

Scenario	Action
Illness or emergency?	Submit a request in LEARN within 48 hours
Varsity conflict or religious event?	Submit documentation in LEARN 10+ days in advance
Have questions?	Contact an Academic Advisor
Disagree with a decision?	Speak to an Academic Advisor for further steps

CONTRIBUTION

The following list might be of help regarding expectations in terms of contribution:

Outstanding Contribution (90-100%)

- Contributes at the highest levels throughout the class.
- Contributions indicate thorough preparation.
- Contributions reflect careful attention to the ongoing discussion.
- Contributions include strong follow-up comments and questions.
- Helps integrate course concepts with other subjects.
- Frequently explains difficult points or concepts.
- Provides sustained strong support to enrich classroom learning.
- Builds and develops outstanding arguments for a position.
- Arguments include strong, valid, and relevant evidence.

Excellent Contribution (80-89%)

- Contributes frequently to discussions.
- Contributions indicate careful preparation.
- Contributions reflect attention to and consideration of the ongoing discussion.
- Explains difficult points and concepts.
- Helps guide class discussions.
- Regularly builds and develops strong arguments for a position.
- Arguments include strong evidence.

Good Contribution (70-79%)

- Contributes fairly regularly to discussions, but primarily in the beginning of the class.
- Contributions indicate consistent preparation.
- Contributions reflect thoughtful responses to the ongoing discussions.
- Raises questions that help focus on difficult points or concepts.
- Occasionally builds reasonable arguments for a position.
- Arguments sometimes include valid evidence.

Fair Contribution (60-69%)

- Contributes irregularly to class discussions.
- Gives occasional indication of preparation.
- Rarely builds on the ongoing discussion.
- Positions are rarely supported by valid evidence.

Poor Contribution (50-59%)

- Contributes rarely to discussions.
- Gives little indication of preparation and thought.
- Contributions confuse statements of opinion with statements of fact.
- Does not aid in providing a positive atmosphere for meaningful discussion.

Unsatisfactory Contribution (0-49%)

- Actively inhibits or impedes the course of class discussions.
- Misses a number of classes sessions.
- Disruptive or unprofessional behaviour.

GROUP ASSIGNMENTS

Students completing group assignments (e.g., 30-hour reports, 48-hour reports, group reports, team assignments) will receive the same grade as their group members for the same submission, with the exception of the impact, if any, of peer evaluation (discussed below). Students are expected to contribute substantially to group work. Every student understands that all group members are equally responsible for the entire project unless otherwise indicated by the professor. If an individual has not contributed substantially to the group's work, the student in question may be severed from the group and receive a grade independent from the group. The faculty reserves the right to assign a failing grade to any student who has not substantially contributed to the group.

If requested by one or more members of a group, your professor may incorporate a peer assessment into the grade for a group assignment. In this case, 85% of your group assignment grade will be based on the group grade; the remaining 15% will be based on your peer's assessment of your contribution to the assignment.

If all group members' performance met expectations and contributed approximately equally, an even allocation of ten points per group member is anticipated. Note that the purpose of peer evaluation is not to assess your group member's knowledge of the subject but rather to assess their cooperativeness and sense of responsibility to the group. Some reasons to allocate more than ten points to a group member include the following: worked significantly more hours than others; contributed most important ideas; played a significant role in resolving team disputes. Some reasons to allocate fewer than ten points to a team member include the following: worked significantly fewer hours than others/ was not available for group meetings; contributed few ideas; played a disruptive role making it difficult for group work to move forward.

All allocations that are other than "10" must be accompanied by an explanation, in particular including examples of specific behaviours that resulted in any decreased evaluation. Please note that the recipient participant will have the opportunity to review the reasons for their evaluations so your comments should be constructive in nature ONLY.

In extreme cases, where it appears that a group member has contributed substantially less than others in the group, the course instructor has the right to seek more information from each group member. As well, the inadequate contribution to the activity may result in the course instructor determining that the student has not completed the activity and repercussions may include (but are not limited to) requiring that student to do a make-up assignment/activity or a grade of zero for the specific report/activity.

In addition, if the course instructor believes that the peer evaluation process has not been completed in a fair manner, the course instructor reserves the right to disregard the submitted evaluations and make a final evaluation of the activity without the peer input. Note that the course instructor may apply a penalty to those involved in submitting unfair evaluations.

CLASSROOM NORMS & VALUES

In our Ivey classrooms, our values guide our decision-making and support our continuous pursuit of excellence:

INTEGRITY
We expect honesty and accountability in our actions and decisions, seeking to inspire ethical and responsible leadership.

INCLUSIVITY
We respect diversity of thought, identity, and perspective, recognizing that inclusive communities foster innovation and creativity.

COMMUNITY
We see strength in positive and supportive interactions, take pride in our collective accomplishments, and have confidence in our long-term success.

COURAGE
We pursue ambitious goals through our commitment to academic and research excellence and believe that, through an entrepreneurial spirit and capacity to act, we can achieve meaningful outcomes locally and globally.

Practicing these values will help foster a community where members contribute to a supportive, inclusive, and accountable culture that pursues excellence, is aligned with our values, and is nurtured through curiosity, respect, mentorship, and recognition.

EXPECTATIONS FOR PARTICIPATING IN OUR LEARNING ENVIRONMENT:

Attendance: Please review Ivey's Attendance and Contribution policy.

Punctuality: Late arrival to class is distracting for faculty and students and detracts from our learning environment. Class times are posted well in advance and available through your course tiles on Learn. Please plan ahead and know when your class is in session. To the extent possible, use time outside of class for other activities (breaks, washrooms, calls, etc.).

Technology in the classroom: In the first session of each course, your professor will establish guidelines and expectations for technology use in their course. Given the differences in course content, delivery and application, technology use will vary between courses. You may notice differences between yourself and your classmates in how they engage with or access technology in the classroom. This is because we understand that to have open and accessible classroom spaces, we may need to proactively accommodate students' diverse learning needs through access to technology. Accommodation for learning differences support equity in our learning environments, so that students can engage, make sense of and contribute to our classroom spaces. For students who require access to learning accommodations related to technology use, please contact Western's Accessible Education team (http://academicsupport.uwo.ca/accessible_education/index.html).

Respect for our academic community: Please note that video or audio recording of classes, guest presentations, events, and other academic activities is strictly prohibited without express written permission of your faculty or Program Services office (in instances outside of your course).

ACADEMIC OFFENSES

Scholastic offenses are taken seriously, and students are expected to read the appropriate policies at:
https://www.uwo.ca/univsec/pdf/academic_policies/appeals/scholastic_discipline_undergrad.pdf

CODE OF CONDUCT POLICIES

- Western Code of Student Conduct: http://www.uwo.ca/univsec/pdf/board/code.pdf

- Ivey Student Code of Professional Conduct found in the Student Handbook.
- Western Non-Discrimination/Harassment Policy: https://www.uwo.ca/univsec/pdf/policies_procedures/section1/mapp135.pdf
- The Code of Behavior for Use of Computer Resources and Corporate Data: https://www.uwo.ca/univsec/pdf/policies_procedures/section1/mapp113.pdf

PLAGIARISM

Students must write their essays and assignments (at Ivey this includes case exams and reports) in their own words. Whenever students take an idea, or a passage from another author, they must acknowledge their debt both by using quotation marks where appropriate and by proper referencing such as footnotes or citations. Plagiarism is a major academic offence.

All required papers (at Ivey this includes case exams and reports) may be subject to submission for textual similarity review to the commercial plagiarism detection software under license to the University for the detection of plagiarism. All papers submitted will be included as source documents in the reference database for the purpose of detecting plagiarism of papers subsequently submitted to the system. Use of the service is subject to the licensing agreement, currently between Western University and Turnitin.com (www.turnitin.com).

PROHIBITED INFORMATION

Unless explicit instructions are received from your instructor to the contrary, your preparation must be limited to the information provided by your instructor(s), plus your own experience and that of your class peers. Class contributions should be based exclusively on your preparation and discussions with members of your learning team or section classmates and not augmented with information obtained anywhere else. Information related to cases that have been obtained from sources other than your instructor in paper, electronic or verbal form is not allowed to be used for class contribution purposes. Such prohibited information includes, but is not limited to, the following:

- Hand-outs, including follow-on ("B") cases
- Exam or report feedback (related to a particular case) for other students or provided in other sections or years
- Notes, spreadsheets, etc. specific to cases (obtained before the case has been taught) prepared by students in other sections or years
- Company information that is not provided in the case (and that is not derived from your own experience)
- Teaching notes

If it is determined that such prohibited information is used in class discussions, such an incident will be deemed to be a violation of Ivey's Student Code of Professional Conduct.

Notes on Use of AI or Other Technology Assistance

Our goal is to cultivate your judgment and wisdom in decision-making and ability to apply knowledge to practical situations. Using generative AI tools can be beneficial for your learning, providing synthesis of vast amounts of information, of helping explore new ideas, and analyzing data efficiently. However, over-reliance on AI, substituting it for your own critical thinking and cognitive effort, will hinder your ability to develop analytical skills, interpret and evaluate the quality of analyses, regardless of whether that analysis is human- or AI-generated.

Our expectations are designed to foster good practices that effectively integrate available tools without being replaced by them, ensuring you develop the essential judgment needed in an increasingly complex world. To be business leaders in the future, we expect that you will use tools available to you in an ethical and thoughtful manner.

To this end, we have the following expectations:

Preparation

1. You should read cases and develop answers to assignment questions without the use of AI. This effort will help you develop analytical abilities that are critical to effective decision making. Following individual preparation, you may engage in learning teams discussions to further your understanding and analysis of the material. Your instructor may also recommend AI tools to further augment your preparation.
2. You should respect the intellectual property rights of copyright holders and not upload copyrighted material without permission to any site.

In-Class

1. In general, use of technology devices in class is not allowed. Some courses may allow the use of technology for specific activities. Using technology when not allowed will negatively affect your contribution grade.
2. Using AI tools in a class session is expressly prohibited and an academic integrity violation as part of the class contribution requirement. An instructor may make an explicit exception to this rule.

Written Work

1. For submitted written work, be clear to acknowledge AI usage explicitly. For simplicity, we consider AI tools to be an external expert who has been consulted by you. In most citation methods, this citation is done as a personal communication or as a footnote at the start of the work that explains the usage.
2. You are welcome to use AI tools for background research. However, the final product should represent your own synthesis of the ideas and must be written in your own words. In a group assignment, the group is collectively responsible for the submission. You are responsible for any plagiarism.

FROM YOUR COMMUNICATIONS PROFS:
Taking care of your physical and mental health & watching out for your peers

Students from time to time may face challenges that can interfere with their ability to learn. These could include relationship issues, stress, anxiety, low mood, difficulty focusing, reduced motivation, or substance use. Such concerns can affect both academic performance and everyday functioning.

Recognizing early signs of emotional or mental health struggles is important. It can help you or others seek support when needed. Some warning signs may include:

- Persistent feelings of sadness, hopelessness, anger, or guilt
- Withdrawing from friends, family, or activities once enjoyed
- Noticeable changes in sleep or eating habits
- Ongoing fatigue or lack of energy
- Difficulty concentrating, remembering, or making decisions
- Restlessness, irritability, or anxious behaviors
- Neglect of personal hygiene or self-care
- Engaging in reckless or impulsive actions such as excessive drinking or drug use
- Chronic physical problems like headaches, digestive issues, or pain that do not improve with usual treatment
- Thoughts of self-harm

Taking care of your health can make a difference. Focus on eating nutritious meals, exercising regularly, getting enough sleep, using alcohol and medication responsibly, and taking time to rest. These habits will help you manage stress, meet personal and academic goals, and stay balanced.

Everyone benefits from support during difficult times. Make use of Ivey and campus resources and remember that asking for help is part of the learning process. Reaching out early can make recovery easier and help you stay on track throughout the semester.
If you or someone you know is struggling with stress, anxiety, depression, or other challenges, we encourage you to connect with available support services. Remember, we are in this together. We care about you as a person and a student.

HEALTH AND WELLNESS SERVICES

As part of a successful student experience at Western, we encourage students to prioritize their health and wellness. Western provides several on-campus services to help you achieve optimum health and engage in healthy living while pursuing your degree.

Students seeking help regarding mental health concerns are recommended to speak to someone they feel comfortable confiding in, such as a faculty member, the Faculty Program Director, or the HBA Program Services team. Students who are in emotional and/or mental distress should also refer to Mental Health@Western http://uwo.ca/health/mental_wellbeing for a complete list of options on how to obtain help.

WESTERN STUDENT EXPERIENCE

Students may also wish to explore supports and services available through Western University at https://studentexperience.uwo.ca/. In addition, as this is a course in Communications, we encourage you to consider seeking support from the Western Writing Support Centre if this is an area for your self-improvement: https://writing.uwo.ca/

OFFICE HOURS/APPOINTMENTS

I do not have weekly office hours; however, I am always willing to set up a meeting either in person or virtual. Email me to request a meeting following the criteria outlined below.

Use professional best practices for emailing me
Start engaging as a professional in the workplace during HBA1. A great deal of miscommunication and misunderstandings originate in hastily prepared emails.

- Use email to share information, set up meetings, or ask simple clarification questions.
- If your question requires more than a one- or two-sentence response, please make an appointment.
- Do not use email to discuss grades or group dynamics. These require a scheduled meeting.
- Always write professionally. Emails should include proper grammar, mechanics, formatting, and tone. Messages that are unprofessional will not receive attention here or in the workplace.

Ensure you include:

- An informative subject line with full identification (name, ID number, course name and number, section, and group number if applicable). *Example subject line:* Jessica Wang, ID 12345678, COMM 3302, Section 9, Group 5
- Proper greeting and closing.
- Signature block with your name.

I will check email daily, Monday through Friday, during normal business hours. You can expect a reply within 24–48 hours. I generally do not respond on weekends or holidays.

Expected behavior when we have guests in class
When we welcome guest speakers, your behavior reflects on you, our class, and on Ivey.. Please keep the following in mind:

- Arrive on time and be settled before the guest begins speaking.
- Show respect by giving your full attention. Laptops and phones should be closed unless they are used for notetaking.
- Listen actively and avoid side conversations.
- Prepare thoughtful questions. Engaging with the guest shows professionalism and interest.
- Address guests respectfully, using their preferred titles (Mr., Ms., Dr., Professor, etc.) unless invited to do otherwise.
- Stay for the full session. Leaving early or packing up before the guest has finished is inappropriate.

Disrespectful behavior will result in a negative contribution or may be escalated to the program office.

Virtual Classroom Etiquette
If the circumstances of the semester ever involve a virtual environment, please do your best to:

- Attend class from a quiet, non-distracting environment. This course is discussion based, so background noise and poor audio will diminish the learning environment for everyone. I do understand that some of you may face challenges with internet, so just do the best you can.
- Have your webcams on during class, unless I tell you otherwise. If you need to step away for a moment, feel free to temporarily turn off your webcam; just remember to turn it back on as soon as you're back at your computer.
- Keep your audio on mute except when speaking or in breakout groups.
- Consider using a headset with a microphone rather than computer speaker audio. Wired ear buds or air pods would work as well. The goal is to have quality listening and speaking.
- Stay in contact to the best of your ability; if you get kicked out of Zoom, please rejoin as soon as you are able. If you can't get back online or into the classroom, try emailing me so I'm aware of your technical difficulty.